HOOK

Your AI coding agent isn't dumb

It's just doing its first day with zero onboarding

WHY IT'S BLOWING UP

97 comments, one shared frustration

A recent HN thread on 'dumb' coding agents hit a nerve

- Devs blaming the model for shallow, confused output
- Same complaint keeps surfacing across agentic coding tools
- Root cause rarely discussed: context, not capability

THE REAL PROBLEM

You wouldn't onboard a new hire like this

Most agents get a task with none of the surrounding context

- No project structure or architecture explained
- No constraints on what not to touch
- No way for the agent to check its own work
- Result looks like confusion, but it's a missing brief

MECHANISM

Three gaps cause most 'dumb' output

Context, scope, and verification, in that order

- Missing context: no map of the codebase or conventions
- Unclear scoping: task is vague or too broad
- No verification loop: agent can't test its own changes

FIX 1

Give it the project context a hire gets

Structure beats raw instructions every time

- Point it to relevant files, not the whole repo
- Explain naming conventions and architectural patterns
- Note what's intentionally off-limits

FIX 2

Scope the task like a real ticket

Vague prompts produce vague code

- Define the exact outcome, not just the general goal
- Break large asks into smaller, checkable steps
- State what 'done' looks like before it starts

FIX 3

Build in a way for it to check itself

This is the step most setups skip entirely

- Tests, linters, or build checks it can run
- A clear error signal it can react to and fix
- Human review at the point that actually matters

TAKEAWAY

Treat the agent like a new engineer

Context, scope, and a feedback loop change the output

- Most 'capability' complaints are onboarding gaps
- Spend setup time before you spend debugging time
- Verification loops turn guesses into reliable work

CTA

What's your agent missing right now?

Context, scope, or a way to verify its own work